COMMUNICATION SKILLS II

MEIC & METI

WEEK 2

EMOTION IN COMMUNICATION:
TRIGGERS, REGULATION, DE-ESCALATION

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TODAY’S CLASS

Theory

- Threat vs safety cues
- Positive communication
- Beliefs about emotions
- Emotional regulation
- De-escalation

Active Practice

- Rewrite for Safety
- De-Escalation Triads

Artifact

- Personal Cool-Down Protocol
- Team De-Escalation Agreement

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AKNOWLEDGMENTS

Elaborated also with materials from lectures by previous Teachers: Sofia Sá and Claudia Silva.

START QUESTIONS

When someone gets emotional, do you think ‘they’re weak’… or ‘something important is happening’?

Is ‘I should be able to control my emotions’ a helpful belief—or a trap?

Why does one short message (‘We need to talk.’) instantly spike stress—even before we know what it’s about?

TODAY'S CLAIM

EMOTION IS INFORMATION

- Emotions signal what matters (risk, needs, values).
- Under perceived threat (status/blame/unfairness), our brain prioritizes protection: tunnel vision > snap interpretations (more certainty, less curiosity) > defensiveness/aggressiveness.
- Regulation + de-escalation techniques reduce threat and reopen problem-solving.

EMOTION IS NOT NOISE

- Emotions guide attention and priorities (“this matters now”). They sinal **relevance, risk and needs**.
- But emotions also bias attention and interpretation—especially negative/threat emotions.
- Under stress/threat, our systems prioritize fast protection over careful reasoning.

Emotion isn’t the enemy of reasoning; unregulated threat responses are.

THREAT VS SAFETY CUES

WHY DEFENSIVENESS RISES?

Threat cues in communication often target:

- competence (“this is basic”),
- fairness (“again?”),
- blame/intent (“you didn’t care”),
- status/hierarchy (“unacceptable”),
- exclusion (“why weren’t you…?”).

Under threat, people often:

- interpret ambiguity negatively,
- protect self-image (“I’m not wrong”),
- reduce openness to feedback and alternatives.

THREAT & BRAIN

WHAT THREAT DOES TO THINKING?

- The prefrontal cortex supports higher-order cognition: working memory, inhibition, flexible reasoning.
- Acute stress **can impair prefrontal functions** (working memory, flexible thinking, impulse control).
- When PFC control drops, we rely more on habit + snap judgments.

Implication:
In a heated moment, logic often fails because the **system is in protection mode**, not analysis mode.
We become less good at complex reasoning, even if we “know the right answer.”

THREAT & BRAIN

“TUNNEL VISION”

- High threat can **narrow attention** and **reduce cognitive flexibility**.
- Performance often peaks at moderate arousal and declines when arousal is too high for complex decision tasks.

Implication:
This is why people become more **certain**, more **defensive**, and less curious during conflict.
The more complex/uncertain the task, the more costly high arousal becomes.

THREAT & BRAIN

“TUNNEL VISION”

Example

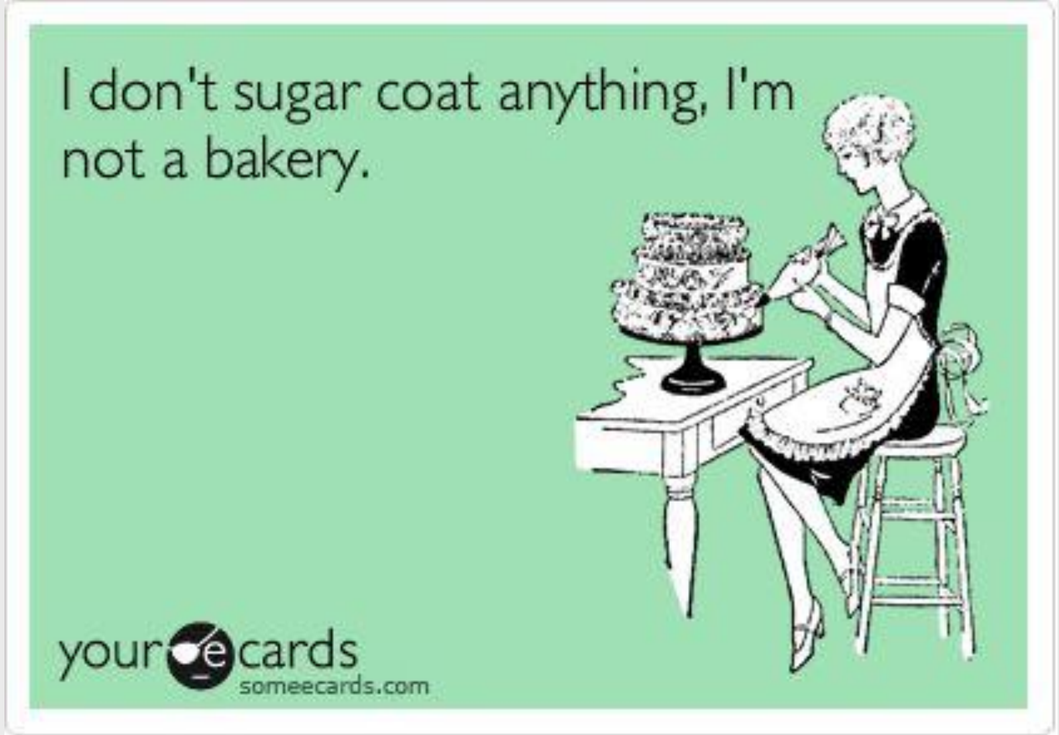
In a small-group discussion, you notice your heart racing and hands sweating. Your attention shifts inward to:

- “Do they see I’m nervous?”
- “My voice sounds shaky.”
- “I’m blushing.”
- “I have to stop this.”

Tunnel vision effect: you lose access to the actual conversation: you miss what others are saying, you give shorter answers, you avoid asking questions, and you may withdraw. Afterwards, you remember mainly the discomfort and conclude “I was awkward,” even if nobody noticed.

POSITIVE COMMUNICATION

IS NOT FORCED CHEERFULNESS!



POSITIVE COMMUNICATION

IS NOT FORCED CHEERFULNESS!

Positive Communication = Increasing Safety (not “being nice”)

- **“Safety cues”** are signals (verbal + nonverbal + structural) that reduce perceived social threat and make it easier for the other person to stay open, think clearly, and collaborate.

Examples

- I’m on your side. Let’s solve it together *(intent and alliance)*.
- *I* can see why this feels frustrating *(validation without agreement)*.
- It’s normal to feel stressed in this situation *(normalizing and permission, reduces shame)*.
- What do you need from me right now? *(respect and autonomy, reduces reactance)*.
- Let’s take this in two steps: first__ then __. *(clarity and structure, predictability feels safe)*.
- I came off harsh - let me rephrase *(repair cues, after tension)*.

BELIEFS ABOUT EMOTIONS

THE HIDDEN LAYER

People hold beliefs about emotions that shape coping outside awareness:

- **Acceptability beliefs**: “negative emotions are unacceptable / weak / should be hidden.”
- **Malleability beliefs:** “emotions can’t really change / I can’t influence them.”

These beliefs are measurable (e.g., Beliefs about Emotions Scale) and linked to how people respond to distress.

ACCEPTABILITY BELIEFS

WHY “DON’T FEEL IT” BACKFIRES?

Beliefs that negative emotion is unacceptable are associated with:

- suppression/avoidance patterns,
- reduced emotional learning and self-understanding,
- links with a range of clinical difficulties in research and clinical models.

Implication:

If you treat emotions as “not allowed,” they often show up as **irritability, shutdown, sarcasm, or rigid arguments** instead of clear problem-solving.

MALLEABILITY BELIEFS

“I CAN’T CHANGE HOW I FEEL” REDUCES REGULATION

Research on implicit theories of emotion shows that believing emotions are more changeable is associated with:

- more active coping and regulation,
- better emotional/social outcomes across transitions.

Believing emotions are fixed can relate to:

- lower emotion regulation, self-efficacy and worse affective outcomes.

EMOTION MYTHS

COMMON UNHELPFUL BELIEFS

- “If I feel this, I’ll be overwhelmed.”
- “If I show emotion, people will think less of me.”
- “Adults should be rational; emotions are immature.”
- “I should cope alone.”

Key point:

Emotions are normal responses.

Regulation improves when we engage skillfully, not when we deny or suppress.

EMOTIONAL REGULATION

REAPPRAISAL VS SUPPRESSION

- Cognitive reappraisal (changing interpretation) is generally associated with better outcomes than suppression.
  - Generate two alternative interpretations.
  - Adopt an observer perspective (“friend voice”).

01

Affect labeling
“name it to tame it”

- Labelling feelings (putting feelings into words) can reduce emotional reactivity.

02

Slow paced breathing
“downshift arousal”

- Evidence supports slow breathing approaches for stress/anxiety reduction.

DE-ESCALATION

WHAT WORKS?

Consensus approach in high-arousal situations emphasizes:

- Engage verbally → build collaborative stance → de-escalate.
    - Pacing (slow, fewer words).
    - Validation without agreement (“I see this matters” ≠ “you’re right”).
    - Name the process (“we’re escalating—let’s clarify the goal”).

De-escalation skills improve with practice!

DE-ESCALATION

6 MOVES

01

Start with your own regulation

- If you are flooded or scared, you won't be effective.
- Slow down: fewer words, calm tone, pause before responding.

02

Create safety with non-provocative presence

- Respect personal space; avoid confrontational stance or "staring."
- Keep body language congruent with your words.

03

One person leads the interaction

- Too many people talking increases confusion and escalation.

DE-ESCALATION

6 MOVES

04

Be concise + repeat calmly

- Under agitation, people process less—use short sentences, simple vocabulary.
- Repetition is part of the method (calm persistence beats arguing).

05

Run the verbal loop (the core)

- Listen → Validate/agree (without endorsing harmful behavior) → State next step → Repeat

06

Move to problem-solving: wants + choices + limits

- Ask what they want/need (even if you can't grant it).
- Offer realistic choices (restores control; reduces fight/flight).
- Set clear limits respectfully ("working conditions").
- End with hope/next step ("how can we work together?")

ACTIVE PRACTICE

ACTIVITY 1

REWRITE FOR SAFETY

Goal: recognize threat cues and rewrite for psychological safety.

Setup: solo, pairs, whole-class.

Steps:

1. Solo (3 min)
2. Pairs (10 min)
3. Pair-swap (8 min)
4. Whole-Class (5 min)

SOLO (3 MIN)

“This is ridiculous. Stop overreacting and just fix the bug. We don’t have time for drama. I need this done ASAP.”

You must:

Underline threat cues in this message (e.g., blame, vagueness, urgency, sarcasm).

PAIRS (10 MIN)

“This is ridiculous. Stop overreacting and just fix the bug. We don’t have time for drama. I need this done ASAP.”

You must rewrite this message, so it includes:

- **Safety cues** (respect, validation without agreement)
- **One clarification** question (build common ground)
- **Actionable next step** (owner + deadline + how to track it)
- Optional: **a choice** (“We can do A now and B later—what’s priority?”)

PAIR-SWAP (8 MIN)

“This is ridiculous. Stop overreacting and just fix the bug. We don’t have time for drama. I need this done ASAP.”

Another pair scores the “safeness” using 3 checks:

- Does it validate without agreeing?
- Does it reduce threat?
- Does it build common ground?
- Is the request actionable?
- Does it reduce ambiguity?

WHOLE-CLASS (5 MIN)

“This is ridiculous. Stop overreacting and just fix the bug. We don’t have time for drama. I need this done ASAP.”

Share your safety rewrites!

ACTIVITY 2

DE-ESCALATION TRIADS

Goal: practice the de-escalation loop:
listen → validate → clarify → next step.

Setup: triads - **A** (upset person), **B** (de-escalator), **C** (observer).

Steps:
2 rounds (10 min each) + 5 min debrief:

- Round 1: B practices pacing + validation + 1 clarification question.
- Round 2: swap roles.

ROUND 1

B PRACTICES PACING + VALIDATION + CLARIFICATION

Harsh review comment (ego/status threat)

A's brief: You received a code/design review comment: "This makes no sense." You feel embarrassed and angry.

B's goal: Reduce threat, reframe to shared goals, clarify what "no sense" means.

Success criteria: B names the process ("let's make this specific"), requests examples, aligns on revision plan.

ROUND 1

B PRACTICES PACING + VALIDATION + CLARIFICATION

Harsh review comment (ego/status threat)

01

B

- **Do:** slow pace, validate, ask clarifying questions, propose next step, confirm.
- **Don't:** blame, diagnose personality ("you always…"), overload with arguments, rush decisions when flooded.

02

C

✅ Slowed pace (short sentences, pauses)
✅ Named emotion/need (validation)
✅ Asked 1 clear question (not a lecture)
✅ Proposed next step + confirmed agreement

ROUND 1

DEBRIEFING (TRIAD REFLEXION)

Harsh review comment (ego/status threat)

- What phrase reduced defensiveness most?
- What phrase escalated unintentionally?

SWAP ROLES

ROUND 2

B PRACTICES PACING + VALIDATION + CLARIFICATION

Missed deadline (teamwork)

A's brief: You're frustrated. You promised a feature to another team and the work wasn't delivered. You feel exposed and disrespected.

B's goal: De-escalate, clarify facts, agree next step.

Success criteria: B validates emotion/need, avoids blame, asks 1–2 clarifying questions, proposes concrete next step (owner + time).

ROUND 2

B PRACTICES PACING + VALIDATION + CLARIFICATION

Missed deadline (teamwork)

01

B

- **Do:** slow pace, validate, ask clarifying questions, propose next step, confirm.
- **Don't:** blame, diagnose personality ("you always…"), overload with arguments, rush decisions when flooded.

02

C

✅ Slowed pace (short sentences, pauses)
✅ Named emotion/need (validation)
✅ Asked 1 clear question (not a lecture)
✅ Proposed next step + confirmed agreement

ROUND 2

DEBRIEFING (TRIAD REFLEXION)

Missed deadline (teamwork)

- What phrase reduced defensiveness most?
- What phrase escalated unintentionally?

ARTIFACT

PERSONAL COOL-DOWN PROTOCOL

PURPOSE:

NOTICE THREAT EARLY, REDUCE AROUSAL, RESPOND WITH CLARITY (NOT IMPULSE)

PERSONAL COOL-DOWN PROTOCOL

01

Notice: name my early signs.
Body (tight chest, fast heart, sweaty hands, tense jaw, shallow breathing, stomach drop, other)
Thoughts ("they're judging me", "this is unfair", "I must defend my self", "I'm failing", "I need to win", other)
Behaviors (speak faster, interrupt, get sarcastic, withdraw/silent, over-explain, message in caps, other)

02

Pause
Use a reset line; slow down.
Example: "I want to respond well, let me take 10 seconds".

PERSONAL COOL-DOWN PROTOCOL

03

Downshift (90 seconds):
breathe + label emotion/need + reappraise (2 alternative interpretations).

04

Respond safely:
validate without agreeing → clarify → propose next step.

PERSONAL COOL-DOWN PROTOCOL

05

Repair if needed:
acknowledge tone → rephrase → re-align.
Example: “I came off harsh – let me rephrase.”

ARTIFACT

TEAM DE-ESCALATION AGREEMENT

GOAL:

REDUCE THREAT, PROTECT DIGNITY, RESTORE PROBLEM-SOLVING

TEAM DE-ESCALATION AGREEMENT

1. **Define escalation signs** (interruptions, sarcasm, raised voice, long defensive messages, blame language, silence/withdrawal, repeating the same point, other).

2. **Pause and reset rule** ("lets pause for 30 seconds" + move to writing for 2 minutes).

3. **De-escalation loop** (facts first → needs/impact → 2 options → decision/next step).

4. **Banned language list** ("always/never" attacks, "this is basic", "stop being dramatic", personal labels – "lazy", "stupid", threats, sarcasm, other).

5. **Channel triage when tense** (if ambiguity/tension is high, we move from chat → quick call; after the call, we document decisions).

6. **Escalation ladder if stuck** (after 10 minutes stuck, we take a break + return later).

7. **Close with decision/owner/deadline.**

READING SUGGESTIONS

READING SUGGESTION

It explains the difference between two core regulation strategies: cognitive reappraisal (changing how you interpret a situation) and expressive suppression (inhibiting emotional expression). It also explains why these strategies tend to have different downstream effects on mood, social functioning, and relationships—very relevant to “why defensiveness rises” and what helps communication recover.

Best parts for this week class: the findings connecting regulation style to social outcomes, can help you see this isn´t just “soft stuff” - it affects teamwork and trust.

J Pers Soc Psychol. 2003 Aug;85(2):348-62. doi: 10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348.

Individual differences in two emotion regulation processes: implications for affect, relationships, and well-being

James J Gross [1], Oliver P John

Affiliations + expand

PMID: 12916575 DOI: 10.1037/0022-3514.85.2.348

Abstract

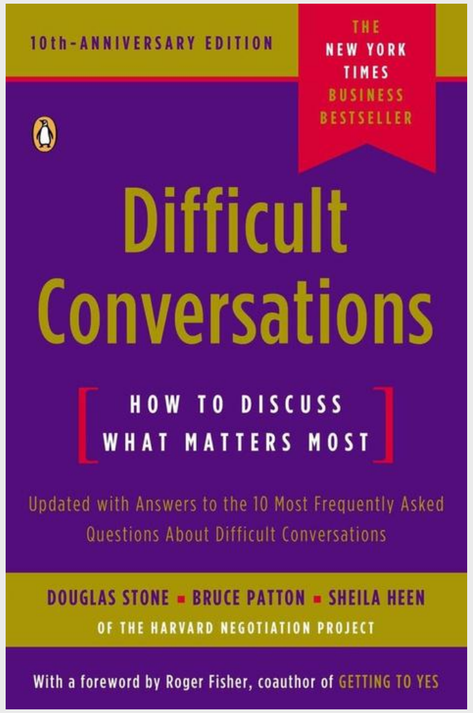
Five studies tested two general hypotheses: Individuals differ in their use of emotion regulation strategies such as reappraisal and suppression, and these individual differences have implications for affect, well-being, and social relationships. Study 1 presents new measures of the habitual use of reappraisal and suppression. Study 2 examines convergent and discriminant validity. Study 3 shows that reappraisers experience and express greater positive emotion and lesser negative emotion, whereas suppressors experience and express lesser positive emotion, yet experience greater negative emotion. Study 4 indicates that using reappraisal is associated with better interpersonal functioning, whereas using suppression is associated with worse interpersonal functioning. Study 5 shows that using reappraisal is related positively to well-being, whereas using suppression is related negatively.

PubMed Disclaimer

READING SUGGESTION

A clear framework for handling emotionally loaded conversations without escalating: separating intent from impact, managing identity threat ("what this says about me"), and moving from blame to contribution.

Best parts for this week class: the chapters on the "feelings conversation" and identity triggers (why we get defensive and lose cognitive flexibility).



ASSIGNMENT 1

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COMMUNICATION DEBUGGING

EMAIL MESSAGE

Setup: individual; write, 20 minutes; oral presentation, max 1 min = **30%**

You must:

1. Identify assumptions / possible misunderstandings (mental models, ladder of inference).
2. Rewrite the message for clarity and psychological safety.
3. Propose 2–3 clarification / de-escalation lines.
4. Deliver a short oral explanation (maximum duration: 1 minute) summarizing: what was misunderstood, what was changed, and why the new version is safer.

ASSIGNMENT 1

COMMUNICATION DEBUGGING

CRITERIA FOR EVALUATION (0-20)

1) **Facts vs interpretations + assumptions (0–5)**

Top marks look like:

- You separate facts from interpretations.
- You identify key assumptions, missing context, ambiguous terms.
- You recognize attribution leaps.

2) **Clarity rewrite (0–7)**

Top marks look like:

- Clear purpose + context + request.
- Concrete next steps: who does what by when.
- Removes vague terms.

3) **Psychological safety language (0–5)**

Top marks look like:

- Neutral tone, no blame.
- Acknowledges the other person (validation) without agreeing.
- Calm clarification questions.

4) **Channel + next step (0–3)**

Top marks look like:

- You choose the right channel (chat/email/ticket/meeting) and say what happens next.

ASSIGNMENT 1

COMMUNICATION DEBUGGING

EMAIL MESSAGE:

“I don’t understand why this wasn’t done. We discussed this last week. Please resolve today.”

Setup: individual; write, 20 minutes; oral presentation, max 1 min = **30%**

You must:

1. Identify assumptions / possible misunderstandings (mental models, ladder of inference).
2. Rewrite the message for clarity and psychological safety.
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THANK YOU